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PPOM I: Lecture # 88

Basic Theoretical Principles of Psychotherapy

Spring 2026

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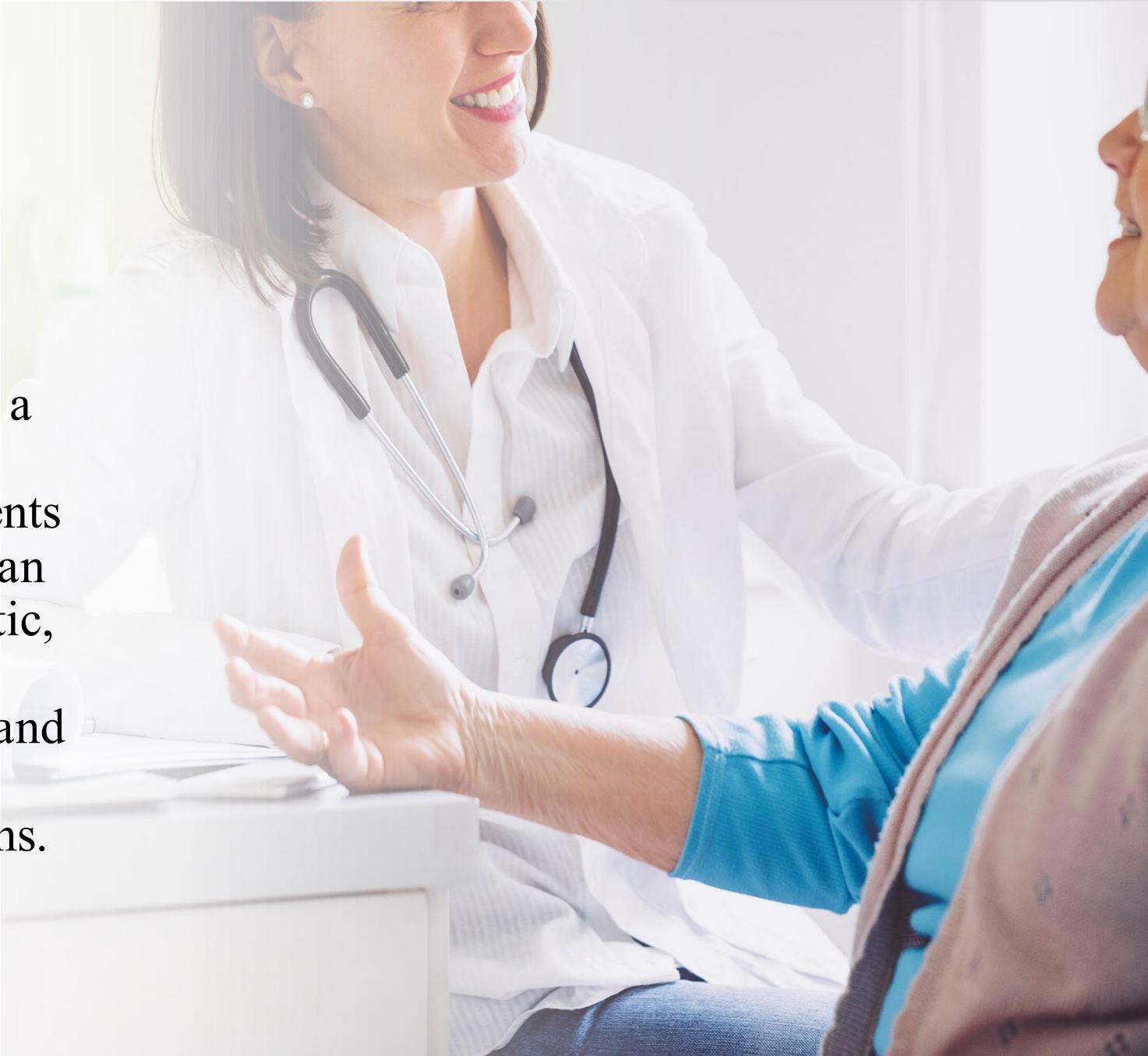
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Session Objectives

At the conclusion of the session/course, the student should be able to:

1. Understand the major forms of psychotherapy- with historical development,
2. Understand the theories and strategies behind these forms of psychotherapy with research and case examples,
3. Understand the patient populations which would benefit from these forms of psychotherapy.



Why should we learn about it?
Medical students should learn about psychological treatments for several important reasons:

1. Osteopathic Principles state we have a wholistic view of a human.
2. By integrating psychological treatments into their education, medical students can provide more comprehensive, empathetic, and effective care to their patients.
3. Knowing about emotional struggles and treatment options, you increase patient compliance with medical treatment plans.

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- **Holistic Patient Care**
Understanding the Whole Patient: Psychological treatments help medical students understand patients as whole individuals, considering not just their physical symptoms but also their mental, emotional, and social well-being
 - **Improved Patient Outcomes:** Integrating psychological care can lead to better overall health outcomes, as mental health significantly impacts physical health



Interprofessional Collaboration

Team-Based Care: Modern healthcare often involves interprofessional teams. Knowledge of psychological treatments allows medical students to collaborate effectively with psychologists, psychiatrists, and other mental health professionals

Comprehensive Treatment Plans: By understanding psychological treatments, medical students can contribute to comprehensive treatment plans that address both physical and mental health needs

Management of Chronic Illnesses

Behavioral Interventions: Psychological treatments, such as cognitive-behavioral therapy (CBT), are effective in managing chronic illnesses like diabetes, hypertension, and chronic pain by promoting healthy behaviors and coping strategies

Patient Adherence: Understanding psychological factors can improve patient adherence to medical treatments and lifestyle changes

Mental Health Awareness

Early Detection: Medical students trained in psychological treatments are better equipped to recognize early signs of mental health issues in their patients

Stigma Reduction: Education in psychological treatments helps reduce the stigma associated with mental health, encouraging more patients to seek help

Enhanced Communication Skills

Empathy and Rapport: Learning about psychological treatments enhances medical students' communication skills, enabling them to build better rapport and trust with patients

Patient-Centered Care: Effective communication is crucial for patient-centered care, which is a core principle of modern medical practice

Preventative Care

Addressing Risk Factors: Psychological treatments can address risk factors such as stress, anxiety, and depression, which are linked to various physical health problems

Promoting Mental Wellness: Medical students can promote mental wellness and preventative care, reducing the incidence of mental health crises

Professional Development

Broadening Skill Set: Knowledge of psychological treatments broadens the skill set of medical students, making them more versatile and effective healthcare providers

Career Opportunities: Understanding psychological treatments opens up diverse career opportunities in fields such as psychiatry, behavioral medicine, and integrated care

Recent Research Findings

Increased Access to Psychotherapy: A study by Columbia University found that access to psychotherapy has risen substantially among U.S. adults with mild to moderate distress since 2018

Teletherapy Adoption: The COVID-19 pandemic accelerated the adoption of teletherapy, making it a significant mode of psychotherapy delivery

Esketamine for Depression: A recent randomized trial found that adjunctive intravenous esketamine was more effective than midazolam in achieving remission of depression and suicidal ideation in adolescents hospitalized with major depression

Cognitive Behavioral Therapy (CBT)

- **History:** Developed by Dr. Aaron T. Beck in the 1960s to treat depression.
- **Definition:** Focuses on changing negative thought patterns and behaviors.
- **Techniques:** Cognitive restructuring, thought challenging, behavioral activation.
- **Effectiveness:** Proven effective for depression, anxiety, PTSD.
- **Recent Research:** A 2024 meta-analysis found that CBT significantly improves emotional regulation in anxiety disorders ($r = .37$)
- **Best Suited For:** Depression, anxiety disorders, PTSD.



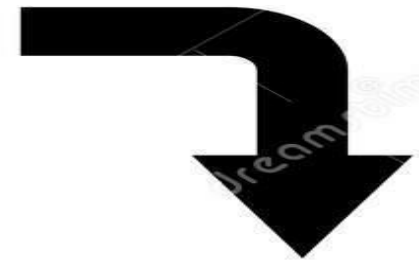
ANXIETY AND PANIC POSITIVE FEEDBACK LOOP

**(BEHAVIORAL)
AVOIDANCE AND
CHRONIC ANXIETY**



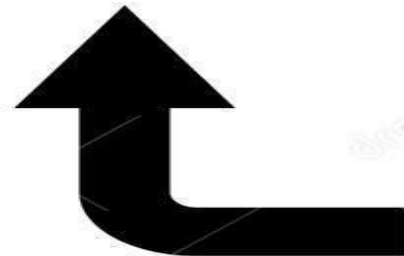
**PANIC
(PHYSIOLOGICAL)**

Tension
Hyperventilation
Increased pulse



THOUGHTS (in anticipation)

I will not be able to sleep
This is where I will panic
I can not cope
I will faint
Maybe I will have a heart attack



THOUGHTS (reactive)

This is so terrifying
I can not control this feeling
People can see me

(COGNITIVE)



**INCREASED
ANXIETY**

Mindfulness-Based Cognitive Therapy (MBCT)



Overview: Combines cognitive therapy with mindfulness practices to prevent relapse in depression.



Techniques: Mindfulness meditation, cognitive restructuring.



Applications: Depression relapse prevention, anxiety disorders



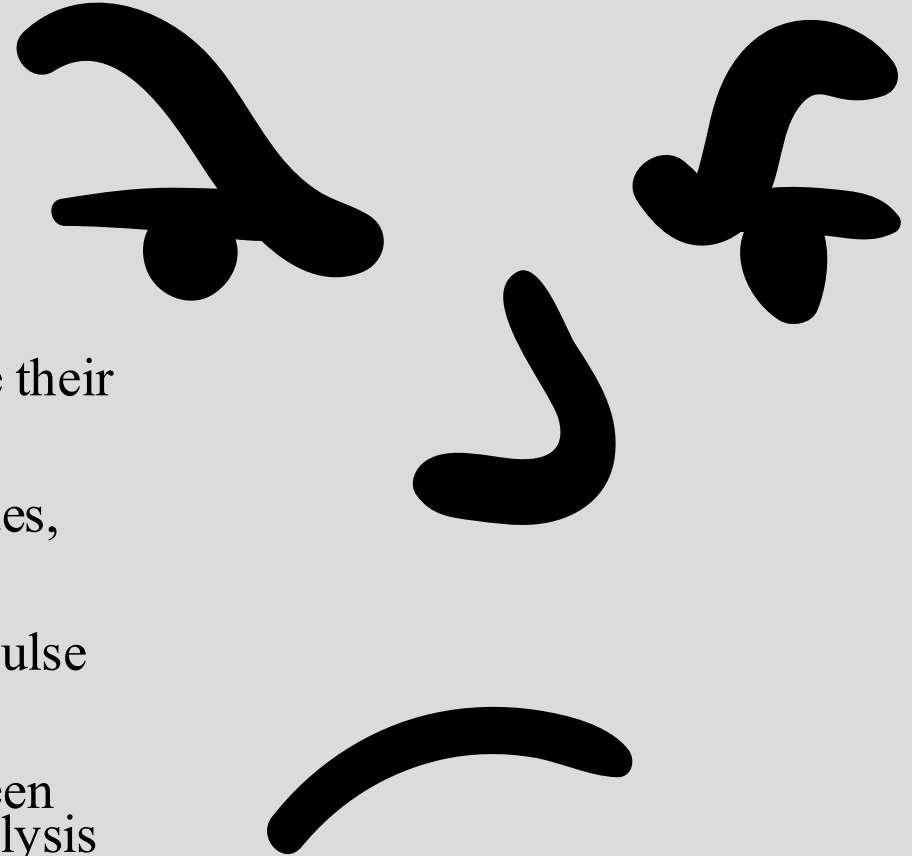
Case Example: A patient with recurrent depression practices mindfulness to reduce rumination and prevent relapse

Acceptance and Commitment Therapy (ACT)

- **Overview:** Focuses on accepting thoughts and feelings rather than fighting them, and committing to actions aligned with personal values
- **Techniques:** Mindfulness, cognitive defusion, values clarification.
- **Applications:** Chronic pain, depression, anxiety disorders
- **Case Example:** A patient with EDS and chronic pain learns to accept discomfort and engage in valued activities, improving quality of life

Anger Management

- **History:** Originated in the 1970s based on cognitive-behavioral principles.
- **Definition:** Aims to help individuals control and regulate their anger.
- **Techniques:** Cognitive restructuring, relaxation techniques, problem-solving.
- **Effectiveness:** Effective for anger-related issues and impulse control disorders
- **Recent Research:** Anger management programs have been found to reduce aggressive behaviors in a 2023 meta-analysis
- **Best Suited For:** Anger-related issues, impulse control disorders



Eye Movement Desensitization and Reprocessing (EMDR)

- **Overview:** Uses bilateral stimulation (e.g., eye movements) to process and integrate traumatic memories
- **Techniques:** Bilateral stimulation, cognitive restructuring.
- **Applications:** PTSD, trauma-related disorders
- **Case Example:** A 32-year-old Iraq War veteran with PTSD processes traumatic memories, reducing symptoms

Cognitive Processing Therapy (CPT)

- **Overview:** A specific type of cognitive-behavioral therapy for PTSD
- **Techniques:** Cognitive restructuring, written trauma narratives.
- **Applications:** PTSD, trauma-related disorders
- **Case Example:** A domestic violence victim with PTSD processes traumatic memories through written narratives, reducing symptoms

Dialectical Behavior Therapy (DBT)

- **History:** Developed by Marsha Linehan in the 1980s to treat borderline personality disorder.
- **Definition:** Combines CBT with mindfulness techniques.
- **Techniques:** Mindfulness, distress tolerance, emotion regulation, interpersonal effectiveness.
- **Effectiveness:** Particularly effective for borderline personality disorder.
- **Recent Research:** DBT has been shown to reduce self-harm behaviors and improve emotional regulation in individuals with borderline personality disorder
- **Best Suited For:** Borderline personality disorder, emotional dysregulation, para-suicidal behavior.
- **Case Example:** A 25-year-old female with borderline personality disorder showed reduced self-harm behaviors and improved emotional regulation after DBT

Applied Behavior Analysis (ABA)

- **History:** Developed by B.F. Skinner in the 1950s, based on principles of operant conditioning.
- **Definition:** Uses reinforcement strategies to increase desired behaviors and decrease undesired behaviors.
- **Techniques:** Positive reinforcement, shaping, chaining.
- **Effectiveness:** Widely used for autism spectrum disorders.
- **Recent Research:** ABA has been shown to improve social skills and communication in children with autism
- **Best Suited For:** Autism spectrum disorders, developmental disabilities
- **Case Example:** A 5-year-old boy with autism improved his communication skills through ABA therapy.

B.F. SKINNER'S OPERANT CONDITIONING

Behaviour modification through Reinforcement and Punishment

Positive Reinforcement

Involves presenting a pleasant stimulus after a desired behaviour, increasing the likelihood that the behaviour will occur again. For example, giving a child praise for cleaning their room reinforces that positive behaviour.



Negative Reinforcement

Involves removing an unpleasant stimulus when a desired behavior occurs, thereby increasing the likelihood of that behaviour. An example is taking away a child's extra chores when they complete their homework on time.



Positive Punishment

Involves administering an unpleasant stimulus to decrease a behaviour. For example, scolding a child for drawing on the walls aims to reduce that behaviour.



Negative Punishment

Involves taking away a pleasant stimulus to decrease a behaviour. An example is removing a teenager's gaming privileges when they miss their curfew.



Extinction

Involves the gradual weakening of a behaviour by stopping reinforcement or punishment. Over time, the behaviour decreases. For example, ignoring a child's tantrums may ultimately reduce their frequency.



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Operant Conditioning in ABA:

•Central concept:

Behaviors are controlled by their consequences.

•Reinforcement:

Positive reinforcement (adding a desirable stimulus) and negative reinforcement

(removing an aversive stimulus) are used to increase the likelihood of a behavior.

•Punishment:

Punishment (adding an aversive stimulus) decreases the likelihood of a behavior.

•Skinner Box:

A specially designed chamber used in experiments to study operant conditioning,

often with animals like rats or pigeons where they can perform a specific action (like pressing a lever)

to receive a reward (like food).

Systematic Desensitization

- **History:** Developed by Joseph Wolpe in the 1950s to treat phobias and anxiety disorders.
- **Definition:** Gradually exposes individuals to feared objects or situations while teaching relaxation techniques.
- **Techniques:** Relaxation training, anxiety hierarchy, gradual exposure.
- **Effectiveness:** Effective for phobias and anxiety disorders.
- **Recent Research:** Systematic desensitization has been found to be effective in reducing phobic reactions in a 2023 study
- **Best Suited For:** Phobias, anxiety disorders.
- **Case Example:** A patient with a phobia of dogs overcame their fear through systematic desensitization.



Psychoanalysis

- **History:** Developed by Sigmund Freud in the late 19th century to explore unconscious processes.
- **Definition:** Aims to bring unconscious conflicts to consciousness for resolution.
- **Techniques:** Free association, dream analysis, transference.
- **Effectiveness:** Useful for deep-seated psychological issues.
- **Recent Research:** Psychoanalysis has been found to be effective in treating complex psychological issues in a 2023 review
- **Best Suited For:** Deep-seated psychological issues, unresolved childhood conflicts.

Theoretical Framework of Freudian Psychoanalysis

- **Unconscious Mind:** Freud believed that much of our mental life operates below the surface of awareness
- **Psychosexual Stages:** Freud's theory that early childhood experiences shape personality development
- **Defense Mechanisms:** Strategies used by the ego to protect against anxiety and conflict

Defense Mechanisms Used in Psychiatry

- **Denial:** Refusing to accept reality
- **Repression:** Unconsciously blocking unpleasant thoughts
- **Projection:** Attributing one's own unacceptable feelings to others
- **Displacement:** Redirecting emotions to a safer outlet
- **Sublimation:** Channeling unacceptable impulses into socially acceptable activities

- **Mature Mechanisms: Altruism, humor, sublimation, suppression.**

- **Altruism**

- **Definition:** Altruism involves unselfishly assisting others to avoid negative personal feelings.
- **Example:** A man with low self-esteem donates time to visit patients in the hospital to feel better about himself.
- **Function:** By focusing on the needs of others, individuals can gain a sense of purpose and self-worth, which helps mitigate their own negative emotions.

- **Humor**

- **Definition:** Humor involves expressing feelings without causing discomfort to oneself or others.
- **Example:** A patient who is uncomfortable about his erectile problems makes jokes about Viagra.
- **Function:** Humor allows individuals to cope with stress and anxiety by finding a light-hearted perspective on their problems, making them more manageable.

Mature Mechanisms (Contd.)

Sublimation

Definition: Sublimation involves rerouting an unacceptable drive or impulse into a socially acceptable activity.

Example: A man who deals with his unacknowledged anger towards his employer engages in a strenuous game of racquetball.

Function: This mechanism allows individuals to channel potentially harmful impulses into positive and constructive activities, thereby reducing internal conflict.

Suppression

Definition: Suppression involves consciously putting aside but not repressing unwanted feelings.

Example: A prostate cancer patient who mentally purposefully changes the subject when his mind wanders to the possibility of a relapse, yet seeks appropriate treatment for his illness.

Function: Suppression helps individuals manage their emotions by temporarily setting aside distressing thoughts, allowing them to focus on more immediate tasks and responsibilities.

Less Mature Mechanisms



Acting Out

Definition: Acting out involves avoiding personally unacceptable feelings by behaving in an attention-getting, often socially inappropriate manner.

Example: A teenager with no history of disruptive behavior begins to talk back to the teacher and fail classes when his parents divorce.

Function: This mechanism allows individuals to express their emotions indirectly through actions rather than addressing the underlying feelings directly.



Denial

Definition: Denial involves not believing personally intolerable facts about external reality.

Example: A man who had a myocardial infarction (MI) two days ago is found doing push-ups in the ICU, stating the MI was not serious and that he does not want to fall behind in his fitness program.

Function: Denial helps individuals avoid the anxiety associated with acknowledging a distressing reality by refusing to accept it.

Less Mature Mechanisms (Contd.)

Displacement

Definition: Displacement involves transferring emotions from an unacceptable object to a more acceptable one.

Example: A man deals with his unacknowledged anger toward his employer by verbally abusing his own office assistant.

Function: This mechanism allows individuals to express their emotions in a safer context, although it often leads to inappropriate or harmful behavior towards others.

Dissociation

Definition: Dissociation involves a separation of functions of mental processes.

Example: A woman who was sexually abused as a child has two distinct personalities in adulthood.

Function: Dissociation helps individuals cope with trauma by mentally distancing themselves from the distressing experience, although it can lead to significant disruptions in identity and memory.

Projection

Definition: Projection involves attributing one's own unacceptable feelings to others.

Example: A man with unconscious homosexual impulses begins to believe, erroneously, that his male boss is making sexual advances toward him to protect himself from recognizing his own unacceptable feelings.

Function: Projection allows individuals to avoid acknowledging their own undesirable traits or feelings by attributing them to others, thereby reducing internal conflict.

Humanistic Therapy

- **Premise:** Emphasizes personal growth and self-actualization.
- **Techniques:** Unconditional positive regard, empathy.
- **Applications:** Personal development, self-esteem issues.
- **Historical Background:** Developed by Carl Rogers in the 1950s.
- **Recent Research:** Effective for improving self-esteem and personal growth.
- **Case Example:** A client with low self-esteem benefits from client-centered therapy.



Interpersonal Therapy (IPT)

- **Overview:** Focuses on improving interpersonal relationships.
- **Techniques:** Role-playing, communication analysis.
- **Applications:** Depression.
- **Historical Background:** Developed in the 1970s by Gerald Klerman and Myrna Weissman.
- **Recent Research:** Effective for treating depression, especially in adolescents.

Short-Term Psychodynamic Therapy

- **History:** Evolved from psychoanalysis, focusing on brief and targeted interventions.
- **Definition:** Aims to quickly address specific psychological issues through psychodynamic principles.
- **Techniques:** Focused exploration of unconscious processes, transference, and countertransference.
- **Effectiveness:** Effective for a variety of mental health conditions.
- **Recent Research:** Short-term psychodynamic therapy has been shown to be effective for depression and anxiety in a 2024 study
- **Best Suited For:** Depression, anxiety, interpersonal issues.
- **Case Example:** A 43-year-old male with depression related to interpersonal avoidance benefited from short-term psychodynamic therapy.

Group Therapy

- **Overview:** Involves therapy sessions with multiple participants, providing support and feedback from peers
- **Techniques:** Process groups, psychoeducational groups, support groups.
- **Applications:** Substance abuse, social anxiety, chronic illness
- **Case Example:** A group of individuals with social anxiety practice social skills and provide mutual support.



Couples Therapy

- **History:** Originated in the 1920s as part of the eugenics movement, evolved in the 1950s to address psychological problems within the family context.
- **Definition:** Aims to improve romantic relationships and resolve interpersonal conflicts.
- **Techniques:** Communication training, conflict resolution, emotional bonding.
- **Effectiveness:** Effective for relationship issues and marital distress.
- **Recent Research:** A 2024 study found that couples therapy significantly improves relationship satisfaction and communication.
- **Best Suited For:** Relationship issues, marital distress.
- **Case Example:** A couple experiencing frequent arguments improved their communication and relationship satisfaction through couples' therapy.



Family Therapy

- **Overview:** Focuses on improving communication and resolving conflicts within the family system
- **Techniques:** Structural therapy, strategic therapy, systemic therapy.
- **Applications:** Family conflict, adolescent behavior problems, substance abuse
- **Case Example:** A family with a teenager experiencing behavioral issues works on improving communication and setting boundaries



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